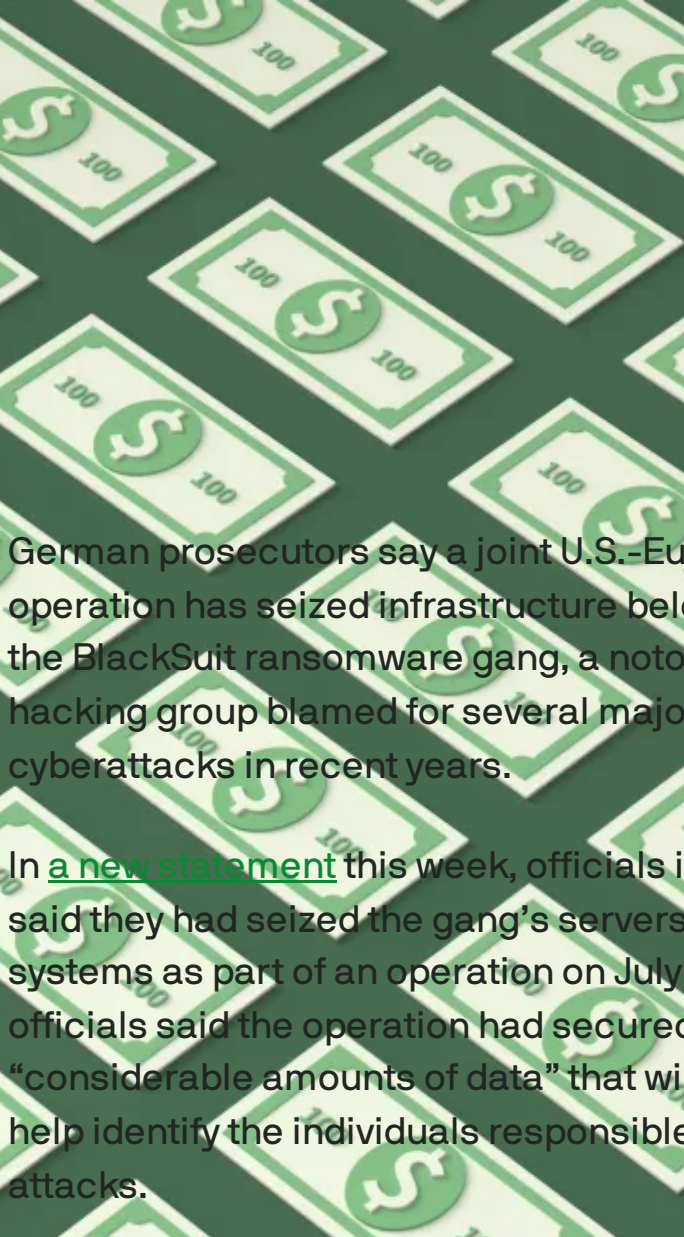


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SECURITY



Authorities seize BlackSuit ransomware gang's servers



German prosecutors say a joint U.S.-European operation has seized infrastructure belonging to the BlackSuit ransomware gang, a notorious hacking group blamed for several major cyberattacks in recent years.

In a [new statement](#) this week, officials in Germany said they had seized the gang's servers and systems as part of an operation on July 24. The officials said the operation had secured "considerable amounts of data" that will be used to help identify the individuals responsible for the attacks.

The officials said they switched off the servers, effectively cutting off the ransomware malware. The statement said BlackSuit had a total of 184 victims worldwide, of which several were in Germany.

At the time of publication, the BlackSuit's leak site on the dark web, which it used to publish files and extort victims into paying a ransom, was no longer loading. It now displays a seizure notice saying the site was taken down by a "coordinated international law enforcement investigation."

The operation went ahead with help from ICE's Homeland Security Investigations unit and Europol, according to the German officials. Representatives for ICE did not return a request for comment.

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U.S. authorities reportedly disclosed the seizure earlier in the week, per [one report](#). It's not immediately clear if any arrests were made.

BlackSuit has been one of the [more prolific ransomware operations](#) in recent years, [targeting U.S. cities like Dallas](#), as well as organizations in the manufacturing, communications, and healthcare industries.

In 2024, U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA warned that the gang was [rebranding from Royal to BlackSuit](#). It's not uncommon for ransomware gangs to spin off or merge with other groups to skirt government-imposed sanctions that make it more difficult to profit from cyberattacks.

Security researchers have [since found](#) that a new ransomware gang dubbed Chaos is likely made up of former members of the BlackSuit gang.

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A SCREENSHOT OF THE BLACKSUIT RANSOMWARE SITE, NOW SEIZED

IMAGE CREDITS:TECHCRUNCH (SCREENSHOT)

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Zack Whittaker

Security Editor |

Zack Whittaker is the security editor at TechCrunch. He can be reached via encrypted message at...

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IMAGE CREDITS: ROBIN GENTRY / GETTY IMAGES

SECURITY

Omni Hotels says customers' personal data stolen in ransomware attack

Zack Whittaker — 7:19 AM PDT · April 16, 2024

Hotel chain giant Omni Hotels & Resorts has confirmed cybercriminals stole the personal

information of its customers in an apparent ransomware attack last month.

In an [update on its website](#) posted on Sunday, Omni said the stolen data includes customer names, email addresses and postal addresses, as well as guest loyalty program information. The company said the stolen data does not include financial information or Social Security numbers.

Omni said it shut down its systems on March 29 after identifying intruders in its systems. Guests reported widespread outages across Omni's properties, including phone and Wi-Fi issues. Some customers said that their room keys stopped working. The hotel chain restored its systems a week later on April 8.

Omni operates dozens of properties across the United States and Canada, and employs more than 14,000 staff, per its website.

A ransomware gang called Daixin has taken credit for the breach.

The Daixin gang said in a post on its dark web site that it would soon leak reams of customer records dating back to 2017. Ransomware gangs typically use such dark web sites to publish stolen information to extort a ransom from their victims.

The gang did not post evidence of their claims, but shared portions of the allegedly stolen files with [veteran data breach watcher DataBreaches.net](#). Per the publication, the gang claimed to steal 3.5 million Omni customer records. A sample of the stolen data shared with DataBreaches.net matched the types of customers' personal information that Omni said was taken.

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A spokesperson for Omni did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Daixin was the subject of [a public advisory by U.S. cybersecurity agency CISA in October](#) after the ransomware crew began targeting businesses across the U.S., including healthcare organizations. The Daixin gang previously took credit for several cyberattacks targeting U.S. hospitals and medical facilities.

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*Do you know more about the Omni Hotels breach?
To contact this reporter, get in touch on Signal and
WhatsApp at +1 646-755-8849, or [by email](#). You can
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Record-breaking ransoms and breaches: A timeline of ransomware in 2024

Carly Page — 6:00 AM PST · December 27, 2024

It was another record-breaking year for

ransomware. When file-locking malware wasn't causing widespread disruption, like downing online services and lasting outages, ransomware was the cause of unprecedented data theft attacks affecting hundreds of millions of people, in some cases for life.

While governments have struck some rare wins against ransomware hackers over the past 12 months, including the [disruption of the prolific LockBit gang](#) and the [seizure and takedown of Radar](#), these data theft and extortion attacks continue to increase dramatically, both in terms of frequency and sophistication.

We look back at some of the most notable ransomware attacks of 2024.

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A rival Tea app for men is leaking its users' personal data and driver's licenses

Amanda Silberling,

January

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LoanDepot

Mortgage and loan giant LoanDepot [said at the start of the year](#) that it had been hit by a cyberattack involving the “encryption of data,” or ransomware. The attack [left customers unable to access account information or submit payments](#), and forced the Florida-based company to “shut down certain systems.” Weeks later, LoanDepot said that the personal data of [more than 16 million individuals](#) were compromised.

Fulton County

The notorious LockBit ransomware gang claimed a January cyberattack on Fulton County, the largest county in Georgia with a population over one million. The attack led to weeks of county-wide disruption, including IT outages affecting phone lines, the courts, and tax systems. LockBit published troves of data from the Georgia county, including “confidential documents,” but later removed these claims from its dark web leak site, which can be an indication that the victim paid the hackers a ransom. While the LockBit gang claimed Fulton County had paid, security experts [reckon that LockBit likely lost most of the data](#) it had stolen when the [gang’s servers were subsequently seized the following month](#) by U.S. and U.K. law enforcement.

Southern Water

U.K. utility giant Southern Water [said early in the year that it was investigating](#) a data theft incident, before weeks [later confirming](#) that ransomware hackers had stolen the personal data of more than

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470,000 customers. The attack on Southern Water, which provides water and wastewater services to millions of people across the south-east of England, was claimed by the Black Basta ransomware group, a Russia-linked gang that previously took credit for [a 2023 hack on U.K. outsourcing giant Capita](#).

February

Change Healthcare

February saw [one of the biggest data breaches](#) of the year — and by far the largest data breaches of U.S. health and medical data in history.

UnitedHealth-owned health tech company [Change Healthcare was hacked by the ALPHV ransomware gang](#), which at the time claimed to have stolen “millions” of Americans’ sensitive health and patient information. Change Healthcare reportedly paid \$22 million to ALPHV before the gang vanished in March, only for the ALPHV contractor who carried out the hack [to demand a second ransom payment](#) from Change.

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UnitedHealth conceded in April that the hack led to [a data breach affecting a “substantial proportion of people in America.”](#) It wasn't until October that UnitedHealth [confirmed that at least 100 million people](#) were affected by the data breach, which included sensitive data including medical records and health information, though the precise number of affected individuals is expected to be far higher.

March

Omni Hotels

Hotel chain Omni Hotels & Resorts shut down its systems in late March after identifying hackers on its network, leading to widespread outages across Omni's properties, including phone and Wi-Fi issues. In April, the hotel giant [confirmed](#) that cybercriminals stole the personal information of its customers during the March ransomware attack, which was [claimed by the prolific Daixin gang](#). According [to reports](#), this gang claimed to have stolen 3.5 million Omni customer records.

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confirmed that the hackers had obtained the personal data of at least 7.6 million people, including customers' Social Security numbers, bank account number, and contact information.

Synnovis

The NHS was forced to declare a critical incident in June after [a ransomware attack](#) on a major pathology services provider, Synnovis. The cyberattack led to canceled operations and the diversion of emergency patients, and also saw the NHS issue a national appeal for “O” blood-type group donors [in the weeks that followed](#) because of delays in matching blood to patients as a result of the weeks-long outages. The Qilin ransomware gang claimed responsibility for the attack and eventually leaked 400 gigabytes of sensitive data allegedly stolen from Synnovis, or [around 300 million patient interactions](#) dating back years, making it [one of the largest ransomware attacks of the year](#).

July

Columbus, Ohio

Some 500,000 residents of the City of Columbus, Ohio's state capital, had their personal data [stolen](#) during a July ransomware attack, including names, dates of birth, addresses, government-issued identification documents, Social Security numbers, and bank account details. Rhysida, the cybercrime gang responsible for last year's [devastating cyberattack on the British Library](#), claimed responsibility for the attack against Columbus in August, saying it had stolen 6.5 terabytes of data from the city.

September

Transport for London

Transport for London, the government body overseeing the U.K. capital's public transit system, experienced [weeks of digital disruption following a cyberattack](#) on the authority's corporate network in September that was later claimed by the infamous Russia-linked Clop ransomware group. While the London transit network continued operating without issue, the incident nevertheless resulted in [the theft of banking data on some 5,000 customers](#) — and forced the transit authority to manually reset the login passwords of every single one of its 30,000 employees in-person.

October

Casio

Japanese electronics giant Casio was the victim of an October cyberattack, [confirming](#) to TechCrunch that the incident was ransomware. The cyberattack, which was claimed by the Underground ransomware gang, [rendered several of Casio's systems "unusable,"](#) causing weeks of delays to product shipments. The attack also saw the theft of

personal information belonging to Casio employees, contractors, and business partners, along with sensitive company data including invoices and human resources files. Casio said the hackers also accessed “information about some customers,” but did not say how many were affected.

November

Blue Yonder

A November [ransomware attack on Blue Yonder](#), one of the world’s largest providers of supply chain software, had a knock-on effect at several major U.S. and U.K. retailers. Two of the U.K.’s largest supermarket chains, Morrisons and Sainsbury’s, confirmed to TechCrunch that they had experienced disruption as a result of the ransomware attack, and U.S. coffee giant Starbucks was also affected, forcing store managers to pay staff manually. Blue Yonder has said little about the incident, including whether any data was stolen, but [both the Clop ransomware gang](#) and the newer Termite crew [claims it has stolen 680 gigabytes of data](#) from the supply chain giant company, including documents, reports, insurance documents, and email lists.

December

NHS Hospitals

Several NHS facilities were disrupted (again) by ransomware in December after a prolific Russia-linked ransomware gang dubbed Inc Ransom [claimed](#) to have compromised Alder Hey Children’s Hospital Trust, one of Europe’s largest children’s hospitals. The Russian ransomware gang, which similarly breached [a major NHS trust in Scotland](#)

[earlier this year](#), claimed it obtained Alder Hey patient records and donor reports, along with data from several other hospitals in the nearby area. Separately, the Wirral University Teaching Hospital — another NHS location not far from Alder Hey — was forced to declare a critical incident after also falling victim to ransomware.

Artivion

December continued to be the month for healthcare-targeted attacks, as Artivion, a medical device company that manufactures implantable tissues for cardiac transplants, this month [confirmed](#) a “cybersecurity incident” that involved the “acquisition and encryption” of data — which reads as ransomware. Artivion said it took certain systems offline in response to the cyberattack.

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Carly Page

Sr. Reporter, Cybersecurity |

Carly Page was a Senior Reporter at TechCrunch, where she covered the cybersecurity beat. Prior to that, she had...

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US sanctions LockBit members after ransomware takedown

Zack Whittaker — 7:45 AM PST · February 20, 2024

The U.S. government has sanctioned two key members of LockBit, the Russian-speaking hacking and extortion gang accused of launching ransomware attacks against victims across the U.S. and internationally.

In a post on Tuesday, the U.S. Treasury confirmed it is sanctioning two Russian nationals, Artur Sungatov and Ivan Gennadievich Kondratiev.

Sungatov and Kondratiev were separately indicted by U.S. prosecutors on Tuesday for their alleged involvement with LockBit.

Kondratiev is also accused of involvement with REvil, RansomEXX and Avaddon ransomware gangs.

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“The United States will not tolerate attempts to extort and steal from our citizens and institutions,” said U.S. Deputy Secretary of the Treasury Wally Adeyemo [in a statement](#). “We will continue our whole-of-government approach to defend against malicious cyber activities, and will use all available tools to hold the actors that enable these threats accountable.”

The newly imposed sanctions mean it is now illegal for U.S. businesses or individuals to pay or otherwise transact with those named by sanctions, a tactic typically used to discourage American victims from paying a hacker’s ransom.

Sanctioning the individuals behind cyberattacks makes [it more difficult for the individual hackers to profit from ransomware](#), rather than targeting groups that can rebrand or change names to skirt sanctions.

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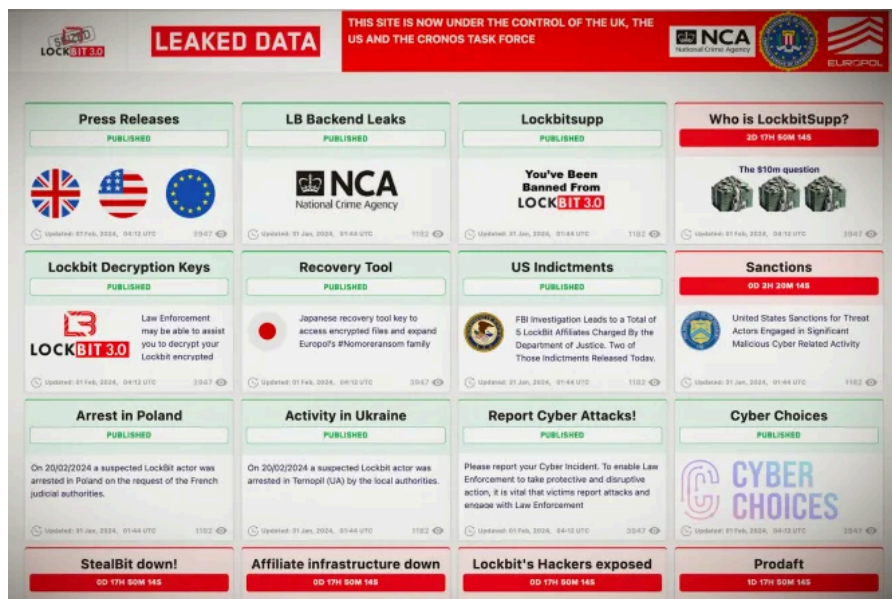
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Those who are caught violating U.S. sanctions law, such as companies paying a sanctioned hacker, can lead to hefty fines and criminal prosecution.

The sanctions dropped hours after U.S. and U.K. authorities announced [a global law enforcement operation aimed at disrupting LockBit's infrastructure and operations](#). The authorities announced the seizure of LockBit's infrastructure on the gang's own dark web leak site, which the group [previously used to publish victims' stolen data](#) unless a ransom was paid.



A SCREENSHOT OF THE NOW-SEIZED LOCKBIT LEAK SITE.

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH (SCREENSHOT)

U.S. prosecutors accuse LockBit's operators of using ransomware in more than 2,000 cyberattacks against victims in the U.S. and worldwide, making some \$120 million in ransom payments since it was founded in 2019.

LockBit has taken credit for hundreds of hacks over the years, including [California's Department of Finance](#), the [U.K. postal service Royal Mail](#) and [U.S. dental insurance giant MCNA](#), affecting millions of individuals' personal information.

The U.S. sanctions announced Tuesday are the latest round of actions targeting the hackers behind LockBit and other prolific ransomware gangs.

In 2022, Russian-Canadian dual national [Mikhail Vasiliev was arrested](#) on allegations of launching multiple LockBit ransomware attacks. A year later, U.S. authorities [arrested Ruslan Magomedovich Astamirov](#) under similar allegations. Both suspects remain in custody awaiting trial.

A third suspect, Russian national Mikhail Pavlovich Matveev, was accused of involvement in several ransomware operations, including LockBit.

Matveev, who remains at large, was [subject to U.S. sanctions in 2023](#), preventing U.S. victims from paying a ransom to him or his associated ransomware gangs, [including Hive and Babuk](#). The U.S. government also has a \$10 million reward for information leading to Matveev's arrest.

In its announcement Tuesday, the U.S. government did not yet name the suspected LockBit ringleader, who goes by the moniker LockBitSupp. The now-seized LockBit dark web leak site says law enforcement plans to release more information on the alleged leader on Friday, including details of a \$10 million bounty for information leading to their location or identification.

Besides sanctions, the U.S. does not ban or otherwise restrict victims from paying a ransom, though the FBI has long advised victims against paying off hackers for fear of perpetuating future cyberattacks. Security researchers say that

ransomware victims who pay a ransom are [more likely to experience subsequent ransomware attacks](#).

Read more on TechCrunch:

[Why are ransomware gangs making so much money?](#)

[Why ransomware victims can't stop paying off hackers](#)

[Do government sanctions against ransomware groups work?](#)

[Why extortion is the new ransomware threat](#)

Authorities disrupt operations of notorious LockBit ransomware gang



A coalition of international law enforcement agencies, including the U.S. Federal Bureau of Investigation and the U.K.'s National Crime Agency, have disrupted the operations of the

notorious LockBit ransomware gang. LockBit's dark web leak site — where the group publicly lists its victims and threatens to leak their stolen data unless a ransom demand is ...

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